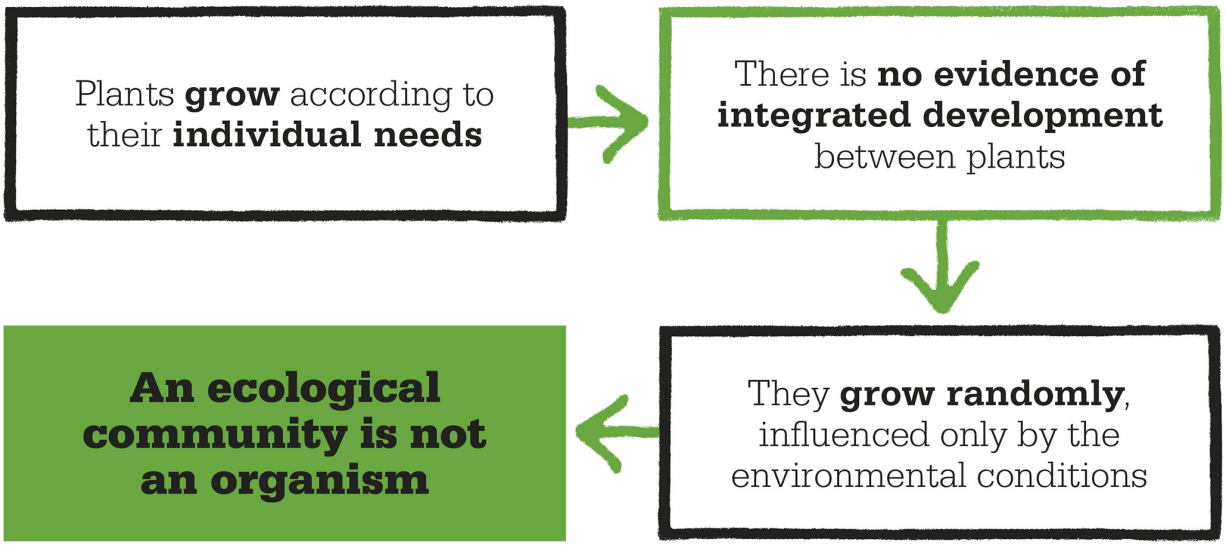
superorganism in which all plants and animals interact to develop the community. A year later, American plant ecologist Henry Gleason dismissed the idea; he argued that plant species have no common purpose but merely pursue their own individual needs. Gleason's hypothesis became known as the "open community" theory. The dispute initiated a debate that still rages in ecological circles today.

Gleason did not deny that plant communities could be mapped and their interactions identified, but he could see none of the integration proposed by Clements. Instead, Gleason believed that groups of plants were random growths of individuals and species, responding to local conditions.



Read accessible description

Individual needs

Gleason maintained that the changes that occur during plant succession, as the composition of a community evolves, are not integrated stages, as in the development of a single organism. Rather, they are a combination of responses from individual species as they seek to meet their own needs within a locality. "Every species of plant," Gleason argued, "is a law unto